

UTEP season ends this weekend

By MARK LEIBSON

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Larry McFarlin's first year as head baseball coach at UTEP is almost over and the most important thing he learned while on the job was the art of being patient.

It's not easy for a young coach to take over a floundering sports program and turn it into an instant success, but a few weeks before the current season began, McFarlin not only said his Miners would have a winning season but a shot at the Western Athletic Conference baseball championship.

Neither materialized.

What appeared to be a successful season turned around over night after UTEP dropped three straight games to San Diego State after the Miners had beaten the Aztecs in the first of their four-game series.

As center fielder Danny Haygood put it, "Everybody just gave up after that series."

Indeed, the Miners appeared to pack up their gear long before this weekend's closing four-game series with New Mexico in Albuquerque, dropping 10 conference games in a row since beating Lubbock Christian College in the middle of April.

McFarlin hasn't allowed a losing season to interfere with his game plan which consists of bringing the best high school and junior college recruits to El Paso. For the past two weeks, McFarlin has seen more of airports and neighboring states than he has his own family.

"Recruiting isn't easy. You have to sell UTEP and the baseball program. You have to sell both ends, academics and athletics," said McFarlin Thursday prior to taking his team on its final road trip of the season with hopes of avenging four earlier losses to the Lobos at Dudley Field.

What makes McFarlin's recruiting duties important, especially this year, is the fact that most of UTEP's talent will be gone after this weekend. UTEP graduates its first baseman, second baseman, shortstop, catcher, two starting pitchers and a pair of outfielders. Had the Miners boasted the pitching to go along with a solid crop of seniors, UTEP might have been a challenge to San Diego State and New Mexico.

The pitching simply wasn't there this year, which was no fault of McFarlin's. When he was hired by Athletic Director Jim Bowden to

replace retiring Andy Cohen late last summer, the recruiting season had ended. McFarlin was left with a baseball team full of recruits from another coaching era.

"It was a very tough year," said McFarlin. "I'm not disappointed because the kids have tried hard all season. This was basically a learning process for me this year. I learned you have to be patient."

The way McFarlin talked back in February, he seemed to feel he could conquer the world overnight, saying the Miners would win the Southern Division of the WAC. With Arizona and Arizona State out of the conference, it was understandable why McFarlin was so optimistic.

"You have to set goals because if you don't, there's nothing to work for," McFarlin said.

McFarlin's next goal is to recruit the best baseball talent this side of the Mississippi. Five recruits from Kansas will meet with McFarlin Sunday evening after the Miners return from Albuquerque.

"It's going to be tough, but I'm going to try and fill all the spots that will be left open when our seniors graduate," said McFarlin. "That's the challenge of coaching."